

7 Ecological Approaches to Corporate Sustainability

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Learning Objectives

- Review key environmental challenges and trends.
- Outline key principles for corporate sustainability.
- Propose a framework to organise ecological lenses within corporate sustainability.
- Call for not merely systems thinking, but also ‘systems action’.

7.1 Introduction

The history of sustainability thinking has evolved significantly in the past centuries and especially decades. This chapter reviews some of the key principles typically adopted within ecological approaches to (corporate) sustainability; enumerates the main (environmental) challenges we face; aims to provide an overview of different dominant theories and lenses; addresses the issue of whether progress is being made; and suggests approaches and actions that each of us can take. In contrast to the other chapters in [Part I](#) providing different ‘approaches’ to corporate sustainability, ecological perspectives emphasise the interrelationships of organisms and their environment. While its roots are in biology, when we speak of ecology we take into consideration a range of perspectives across different sciences. Our focus is broadly speaking on examining how firms relate to and are embedded in their natural environments. Before moving forward, let us start with a thought experiment: If you were to imagine an environmentally sustainable company, what would it look like? Can you name such a sustainable company?

A good place to start the discussion of ecological aspects of sustainability is the Brundtland (1987) Commission’s classic definition of sustainable development as ‘development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.’ This definition makes sustainability inter-generational and thus adopts a longer time horizon than the quarterly or yearly targets or planning cycles of many companies. It also clearly links to available natural resources and explicitly calls for meeting needs instead of aiming

to maximise societal benefits, thus invoking a sense of balance between social, ecological and economic dimensions of sustainability (or ‘people, planet and profit’ in corporate sustainability parlance). We should note that the Brundtland report also calls for intra-generational (i.e., within currently existing generations) justice. While sustainable development is commonly understood as anthropocentric (i.e., human-centric), a central aspect to this notion is also inter-species justice (i.e., between different living species beyond humans), bringing in a more bio-centric notion of development. If we have now defined sustainable development, what then is a sustainable corporation? A firm which follows the principles of sustainable development? Yes ... and no. Let’s reflect on this question in this chapter. Ultimately (spoiler alert!), we will argue that (environmental) sustainability is not an organisational characteristic, but should be understood as a systemic (inter-organisational) element. We will examine companies not as external actors with a relationship to the environment, but rather as embedded within their natural environments.

For those of you interested in learning more about how social and environmental perspectives have co-evolved in management, but emerged from different origins, we recommend Bansal and Song’s (2017) examination of the roots of corporate responsibility and corporate sustainability. For those of you interested in a broader review of the history of environmental sustainability, we recommend the work of Caradonna (2014). In short, the notion and discussion related to sustainability discourse has changed considerably over the years and it has become one of the most prevailing topics of debate and discussion within society.

As a rather broad characterisation, we can speak of contrasting a critical call for having fewer material things (consumption) and using fewer resources (environmental impact) to more positive notions of regeneration at the local level and flourishing at the societal level. At the company level, we have seen a more internally oriented enterprise integration (focusing on environmental management) being complemented with a more externally oriented market transformation (focusing on the purpose and sustainability impact of the firm) (see Hoffman and Roy in [Chapter 23](#) of this book). We should note while we focus on the corporate perspective to environmental sustainability, the role of other societal sectors such as governments' environmental legislation and regulation (see [Chapters 6](#) and [12](#) of this book) and civil society contributions (including environmental non-governmental organisations) (see [Chapter 13](#) of this book) are invaluable. Next, let's turn to a more detailed review of important trends and challenges.

7.2 Ecological Trends and Challenges

In 1992, over 1,700 independent scientists, including the majority of living Nobel laureates in the sciences at the time, published a 'Warning to Humanity' (Union of

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Concerned Scientists, [1992](#)). This warning began with the words: 'Human beings and the natural world are on a collision course.' This call outlined dangerous trends regarding climate change, population growth, freshwater availability, ozone depletion, overfishing, deforestation and biodiversity. In the over three decades that have passed since this warning, have we been able to address these major environmental challenges? The answer is, as you may have guessed it, a resounding 'no'. The assessment of the world's scientific community is alarming (Ripple et al., [2017](#)). While there have been some successes – most notably regulation addressing atmospheric ozone depletion and increasing the area of land dedicated to conservation, as well as a changing global awareness of pressing environmental challenges – the broader trends have continued and in many cases intensified. Quite simply, there are more of us (increasing population), we are using more resources (increasing affluence) and we are severely harming our natural ecosystems (increasing impact). We should also note that, from the perspective of environmental justice, those with high socio-economic status have a disproportionately high environmental impact (see Nielsen et al., [2021](#)).

In fact, human beings' impacts on the planet are considered so vast that we have started calling this epoch the Anthropocene, the age of humans. The Anthropocene refers to the proposed name of the current geological epoch in which we are living. For more on the Anthropocene as it relates to climate change, see [Chapter 23](#) of this book and its [Figure 23.6](#) depicting the 'Great Acceleration' of environmental, social and economic trends. Rising population, greenhouse gas emissions and temperature go hand in hand with deforestation, loss of biodiversity and decrease in freshwater resources (Ripple et al., [2017](#)). What is common to all these trends is that they indicate either very rapid growth or very rapid decline, each involving significant environmental impacts.

Impacts of human beings on the planet abound, ranging from subtle but significant changes in the composition of the atmosphere (causing climate change), to large changes to the surface of the planet due to agriculture, deforestation, urbanisation and mining (leading to less than 3 per cent of the world's land area to be ecologically intact; see Plumptre et al., [2021](#)), and to impacts on oceans and marine ecosystems, ultimately humans becoming the main cause of the ongoing sixth mass extinction period that our planet has seen. We have now come to a point where human-made objects (from cell phones to buildings and T-shirts to aeroplanes) outweigh all living things (meaning all plants, bacteria, animals and, well, us) (Elhacham et al., [2020](#)).

It is important to note that human societies have seen incredible developments over the past century. World population has more than quadrupled in this time and is likely to stabilise and plateau in the future. During the past century, average life expectancy has more than doubled, literacy rates have more than quadrupled, the world economy has increased by a factor of 80, the share of people living in extreme

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poverty has dropped by a factor of 8 and we have seen astonishing developments in science and technology. Unfortunately, this human development has most often come at a significant ecological cost. While we see the economy growing (produced capital), the social aspects (human capital) have not grown at the same pace and the ecological consequences have been severe (natural capital) (Managi and Kumar, [2018](#)). Business and its sustainability can be seen as both a (main) culprit and as (part of) a solution to these challenges.

7.3 Ecological Principles of Corporate Sustainability

Before trying to define sustainability for a firm, it is good to determine key ecological principles and aspirations of how we should look at the topic area in general. The discussion of sustainability as it pertains to business firms is founded on some key principles which are listed and briefly presented below. Here we echo and revisit some of the more general principles as listed in the introductory chapter of this book, but from an environmental perspective.

Science-based. Corporate sustainability is deeply rooted in sustainability science and engineering as well as management studies. In essence, the foundation of sustainability thinking and action is evidence-based. It is only through evidence of ecological impact that we can start to tackle sustainability assumptions or myths, such as the idea that it is individual material consumption choices that will save the world or that the rising wealth of the poorest on the planet will have the largest negative environmental impact in the future.

Practical. While much of this chapter is dedicated to specific ways of seeing or understanding the topic, corporate sustainability is inherently a practical problem of how to minimise the negative environmental impacts and maximising positive environmental impacts of a business model (for a discussion of business models, see [Chapter 19](#) of this book).

Contextual. The old adage from town planning – ‘Think global, act local’ – has a lot of truth to it. Universal solutions to sustainability are rare and all approaches should be adapted to the local context. Environmental innovations or practices that work in Cairo might not work in Copenhagen or Caracas.

Just. A central consideration is the inclusive nature of participation to environmental sustainability. Important questions include: Who gets to participate and who gets to sit at the table where decisions about environmental rules are made? Are different stakeholders part of the conversation or are they being ‘talked at’? Is the discussion only between friendly stakeholders or are ‘hateholders’ also invited to join? Ultimately, environmental issues such as climate change have important social justice elements which are important to consider when assigning costs and thinking of solutions.

Systemic. Systems thinking is a popular term within sustainability, but it is easier said than done. When we look at business, not only individuals and organisations, but as a broader system with interrelated parts, we can have a better understanding of sustainable change over time. This allows us to see the embeddedness of social and economic activity into ecological systems, to move away from only looking for silver-bullet (typically technological) solutions to every environmental problem, to design for resilience, and appreciate the perspectives and contributions of different actors within the system. While climate change and carbon dioxide gets a lot of attention (with several companies pledging to go carbon neutral, net zero carbon or carbon negative/climate positive), it is good to remember that climate and carbon dioxide are just one piece of the puzzle, alongside biodiversity and biochemical flows, among other concerns.

Balanced. Corporate responsibility and sustainability literature has traditionally been based on the notion of triple bottom line – the economic, environmental and social responsibilities of firms (Elkington, 1997). Many business decisions include an interplay of these elements. To use a simple example, producing a safer car (social benefit) typically involves more materials making the car heavier and less fuel-efficient (environmental cost) and is more expensive (economic cost). While the trade-offs are often more difficult to estimate in practice, a balance between economic, environmental and social considerations needs to be reached at the individual, organisational and societal levels. Ultimately, what these balances at different levels look like is heavily influenced by normative, ethical, political and ideological considerations. In this chapter on ecological approaches, we emphasise that ecological sustainability is the fundament and that social and economic sustainability cannot thrive without it.

Transformational. Sustainability is all about transformation and change. We often contrast incremental change with a more transformational one. While the discussion in practice is often about how to be ‘a little less unsustainable’, the imperative of sustainability is for wider systemic change. Hence, the contemporary calls for energy transitions and aggressive climate goals. In fact, many if not most of the tools and approaches we need for sustainable change already exist. In this way, cultural change becomes essential alongside technological change.

Now that we have a set of ecological principles that we can utilise to start looking for solutions (building on the introductory chapter and the other approaches presented before this chapter), let’s evaluate different lenses that have been proposed to approach (corporate) sustainability.

7.4 Lenses in (Corporate) Sustainability

Over the past decades, a range of ecological paradigms, theories, concepts and approaches have been proposed and developed to examine the role of corporations

and business in general in environmental sustainability. Here, we will refer to them as lenses. Several fields as diverse as environmental and Earth system sciences, economics, philosophy and indigenous (in itself interdisciplinary) studies have contributed to this endeavour and developed their own related sub-fields (such as environmental economics and environmental ethics). Since it would not be feasible to provide a comprehensive overview, for the purposes of this chapter, we select twelve lenses especially prevalent in the field of management and categorise these according to their nature. These include progress indicators, critiques of growth, social science and indigenous contributions, sustainability innovation concepts and approaches for sustainable organising.

7.4.1 Progress Indicators

As the famous saying goes: ‘you can’t manage what you can’t measure’. Well, in the case of sustainability, countless ways to measure it have been proposed over the decades. Here, we will look at three interrelated frameworks which aim to measure progress on a set of themes or indicators: the UN Sustainable Development Goals, Planetary Boundaries and Doughnut Economics.

As presented in [Chapter 1](#), the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are a roadmap for global sustainability. They consist of a set of seventeen goals and 169 more specific targets. The SDGs are part of the so-called Agenda 2030, meaning that the UN General Assembly set these goals to be achieved by the year 2030. The SDGs were preceded by the Millennium Development Goals, targets intended to be achieved between 2000 and 2015. The SDGs were designed based on multi-stakeholder consultation and thus bring in the perspectives of different societal sectors and actors. The SDGs are all interconnected and even partially contradictory. For example, industrial development (SDG 9) can go against climate action (SDG 13) without a deep transformation and decarbonisation of the economy. Ultimately, the Stockholm Resilience Centre (2015) has argued that the SDGs should be rearranged as a ‘wedding cake’ as depicted in [Figure 7.1](#). This means that the biosphere-related goals related to life on land, life below water, clean water and sanitation, and climate action should be non-negotiable and thus have priority over societal and economic goals. From a corporate sustainability perspective, the SDGs have become a popular way for larger multinational firms, such as health technology conglomerate Philips and multinational consumer goods company Unilever, to describe their social and environmental responsibility. Nonetheless, we should note that many other firms promoting their contributions to the SDG targets have also been accused of greenwashing (i.e., overselling or overemphasising the environmental benefits of their products or services).

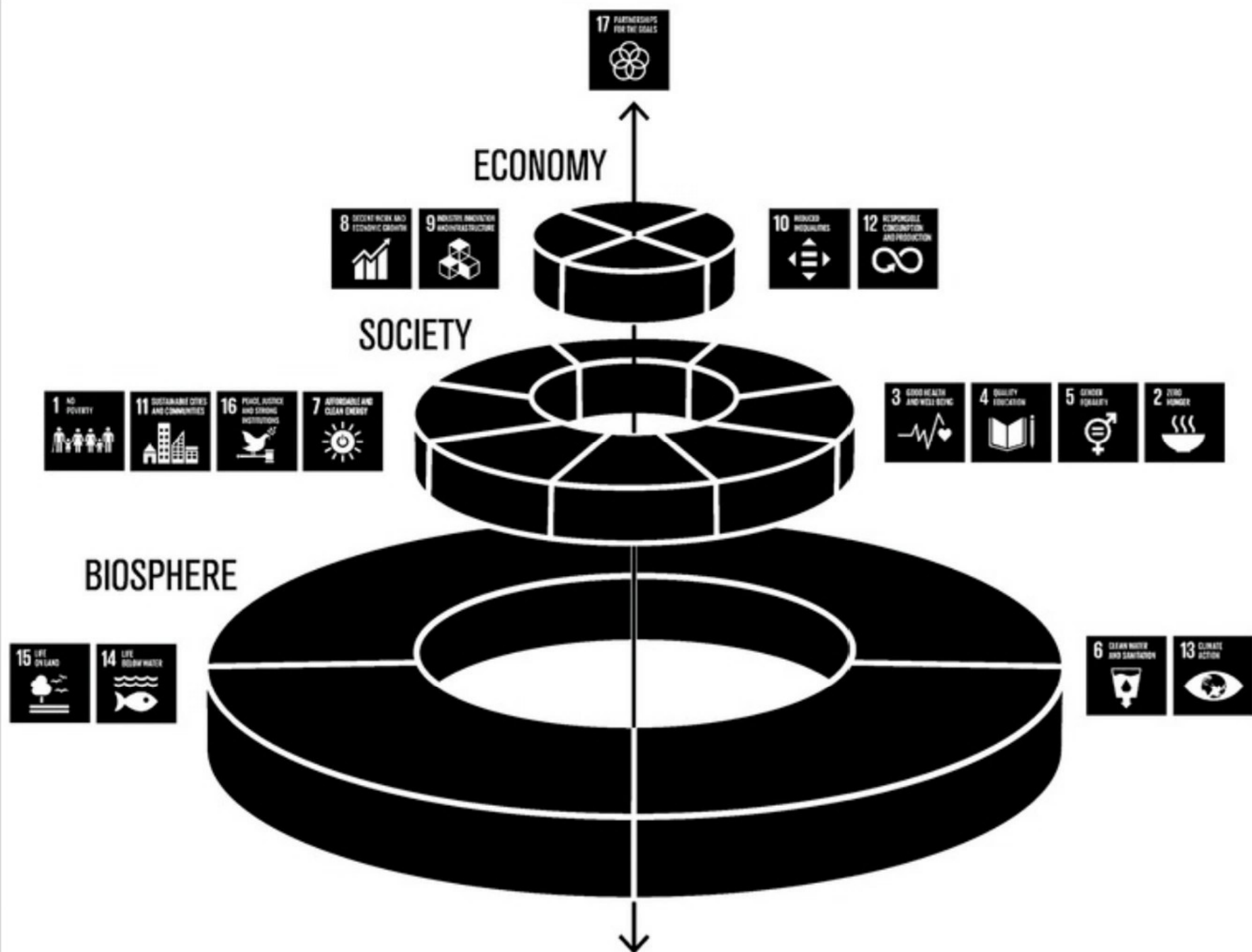


Figure 7.1



A second progress indicator are the Planetary Boundaries. We already learned about them in [Chapter 1](#), setting the scene for this book, but they are worth re-examining here. The planetary boundaries are a set of science-based indicators aiming to determine a ‘safe operating space for humanity’ (Rockström et al., [2009](#)). They were

originally proposed in 2009 and have since become an influential way to understand sustainability from an Earth systems perspective. The basic premise of this framework is that we can scientifically identify and evaluate progress on key planetary boundaries that we should stay within to avoid catastrophic abrupt environmental change. These nine boundaries are listed in [Figure 7.2](#) and include environmental issues such as climate change, ozone depletion, ocean acidification and biosphere integrity. Alarmingly, we have already surpassed the safe operating space on five boundaries: climate change, loss of genetic biodiversity (i.e., species extinction), land-system change (i.e., humans transforming natural landscapes through, for instance, deforestation), biogeochemical flows (i.e., related to our use of phosphorus (P) and nitrogen (N)) and novel entities (chemicals and plastics). While these sound like separate environmental (and quite technical!) topics, they are all interconnected and act as both a warning system and a dashboard to manage these planetary risks. In terms of corporate sustainability, the planetary boundaries can be difficult to adapt to an organisational context. Typically, they can be used to explore firm activities in a geographically contextualised way (see Whiteman et al., [2013](#)), but can be difficult to adapt to the company context.

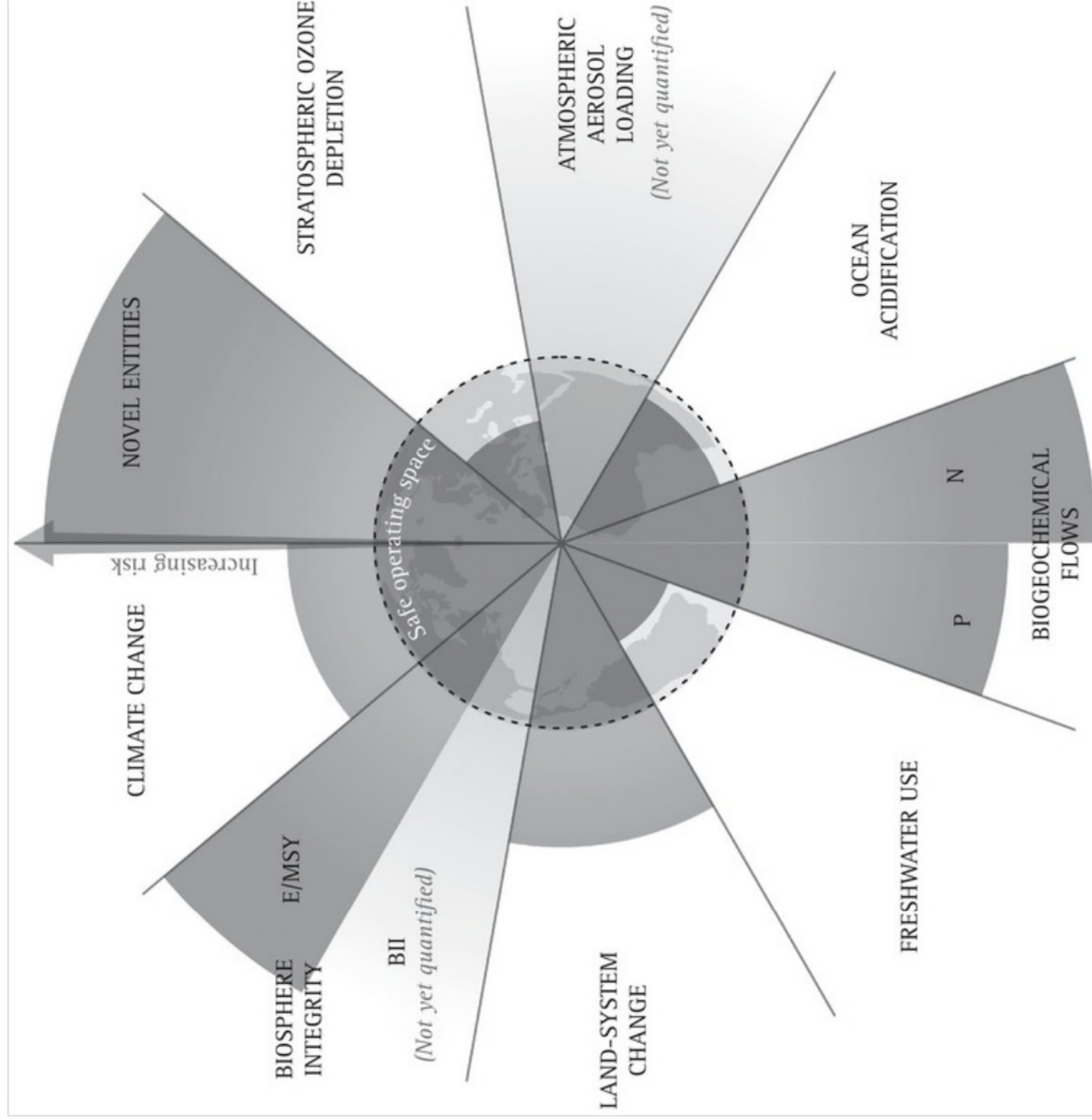


Figure 7.2



A third progress indicator is Doughnut Economics, which is an extension of the planetary boundaries framework combined with insights from scholars such as Amartya Sen and Martha Nussbaum. Doughnut Economics is a framework developed by Professor Raworth (2017). Its visual representation is presented in [Figure 7.3](#). What makes the doughnut interesting is that it is able to depict both social ambitions and planetary boundaries in one framework. The outer circle or edge of the doughnut is formed by the planetary boundaries that were described above. The inner circle or edge represents basic social needs which are seen as

essential to human life (for instance, water, food, education and healthcare). The main idea is that we need to meet the social floor without surpassing the ecological ceiling. While the Doughnut Economics framework is used by companies to a lesser extent than, for instance, the SDGs, it can be a useful tool to see interconnections and understand systemic impacts. Other organisations, such as the City of Amsterdam in the Netherlands, have adopted Doughnut Economics as a central framework to assess sustainability.

■ Beyond the boundary
■ Boundary not quantified

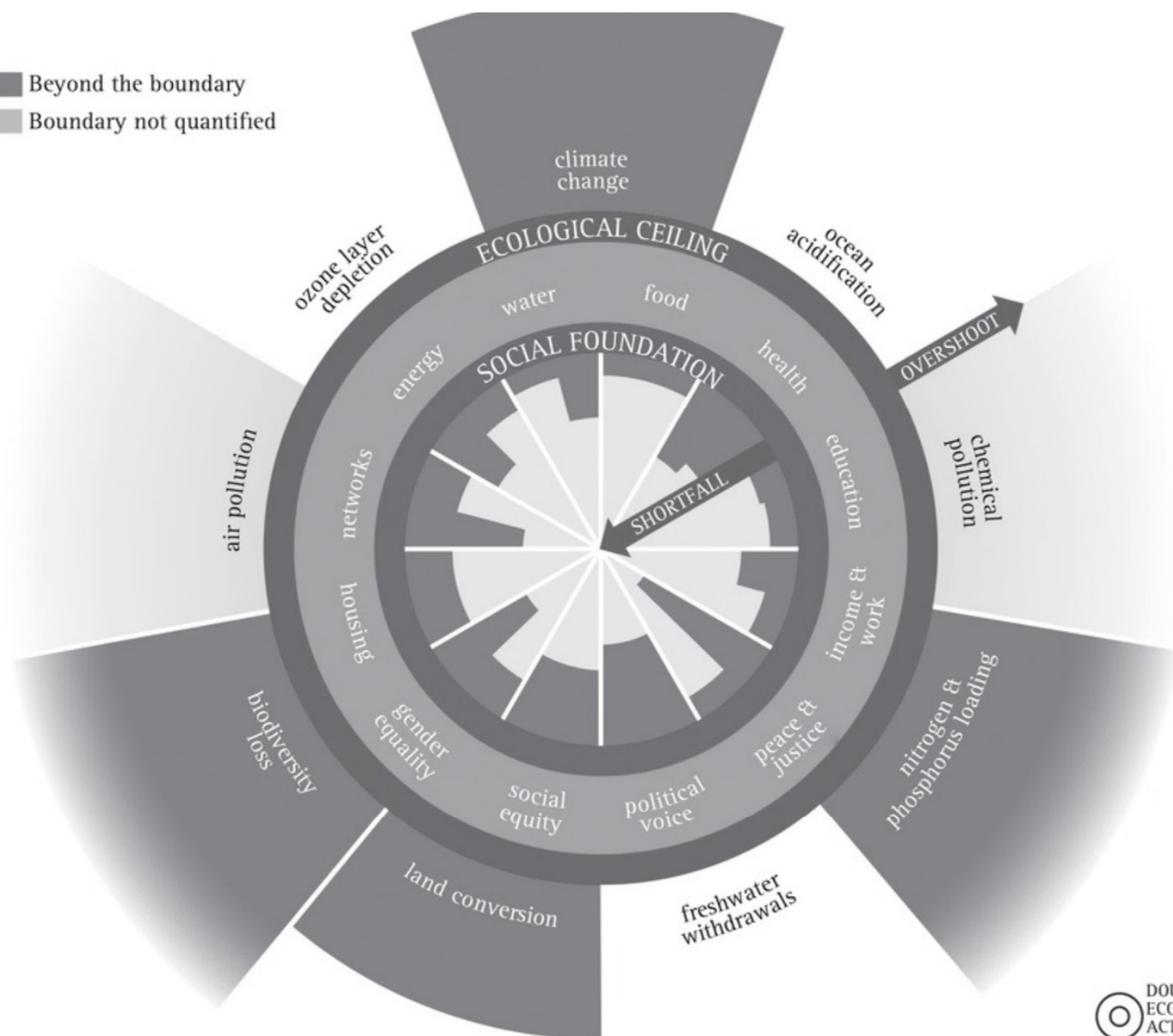


Figure 7.3



7.4.2 Critiques of Economic Growth

Is economic growth necessary for sustainable development? A large academic and practical movement has come to question what has been taken for granted ever since the post-World War II reconstruction period: Economic growth is the best measure of societal development and gross domestic product is the best measure of progress. Ideally, what we want to see is that economic growth leads to societal growth (i.e., a coupling of both as they go hand in hand) and that ecological impact and resource use decreases as the economy grows (i.e., that we are able to decouple economic growth and environmental impact by dematerialising our economies). These debates go back to the 1970s (Meadows et al., 1972; Easterlin, 1974) and unfortunately the collective evidence thus far seems to point to the contrary (see Figure 7.1; Parrique et al., 2019). First, social welfare increases alongside economic growth only up to a point, after which social welfare ceases to increase despite economic growth. Second, Western societies have not been able to decouple economic growth from material consumption: production has merely moved elsewhere while material consumption has stayed the same or typically increased.

This critique of economic growth takes many forms, but has crystallised into a movement called Degrowth. Degrowth, or in French *décroissance*, initially strikes as a negative term, being ‘against something’ (even if the original idea has a positive connotation). Certainly, this lens takes a strong stance against the ecological harm caused by the pursuit of continuous growth, problematises the idea that the purpose of human organisation is economic productivity and growth, and speaks against a Western notion of development. Nonetheless, it also aims to provide alternatives, including better metrics of prosperity, a mindset of sufficiency and a focus on participatory local economies. Degrowth does not imply a reduction of well-being (quite the contrary!), but involves a rethinking of how we see and measure well-being. This broad and varied lens has many nuances and has taken multiple forms, coining terms such as degrowth, steady state economics, prosperity without growth, post-growth and agrowth (the latter referring to being agnostic about growth) (see Borowy and Schmelzer, 2017; Jackson et al., 2020). Ultimately, it may be that the future ideological battle lines of sustainability may be drawn between degrowth (a critique of the global capitalistic system advocating for social and ecological well-being), green growth (a business-friendly, sustainability-oriented and technology- and innovation-focused vision of sustainability) and forced green (a regulatory-driven transformation towards sustainable societies).

7.4.3 Social Science and Indigenous Contributions

Next, we turn to social sciences and indigenous studies and selectively pick lenses that can be insightful to our understanding of corporate sustainability: ecological economics; environmental justice; and indigenous knowledge. Ecological economics is a field of research which sees economies and natural ecosystems as

interdependent and co-evolving. This lens is often critical of mainstream economics and grounds its analysis in physical reality within a specific temporal and spatial context. In this sense, natural resources flow through the economy instead of the economy being separated from the natural world.

A related lens to ecological economics is the notion of environmental justice. This notion underscores the social-justice-related elements of the governance and implementation of environmental laws and regulations. It includes elements of distributive and procedural justice. If we take climate change as an example, a distributive justice perspective highlights that the most vulnerable populations are typically the least culpable in producing the broader changes affecting them. From a procedural justice perspective, we can examine what roles and responsibilities different national governments take in global climate agreements in light of their current and historical greenhouse gas emissions. These perspectives beg the question: Are certain aspects or forms of development acceptable to some nations and not to others?

Indigenous studies (an interdisciplinary field in itself) and knowledge offer a broad spectrum of insights on sustainability originating from different contexts. Through thousands of years, indigenous systems of knowledge have been based on a profound connection between humans and nature, often subjugated by colonial powers. Banerjee and Arjaliès (2021) argue that as our current ecological crisis is a product of human–nature dualism and Enlightenment thinking, these cannot be the basis of looking for solutions to the crisis.

7.4.4 Sustainability Innovation Concepts

Within the field of innovation, several popular concepts have been launched throughout the years to examine sustainable change. Here, we discuss the circular economy, sustainability transitions and sustainable business models.

A circular economy is an industrial system that is restorative by design. It is a redesign of the current mode of production and economy from a take-make-waste culture to a circular one. The central idea is not only to recycle waste, but to stop producing waste in the first place. The key principles of the circular economy are to design out waste and pollution, keep products and materials in use, and regenerate natural systems (Ellen MacArthur Foundation, [2013](#), [2019](#)). From a business perspective, circularity can involve a range of different business models, such as eco-design, sharing or virtualising products or services. For an overview of sustainable (including circular) business models, see [Chapter 19](#), and for a discussion of social and sustainable entrepreneurs, see [Chapter 9](#).

Another innovation-related lens which examines corporate sustainability from an ecological perspective is the sustainability transition lens. A sustainability transition is defined as a ‘radical transformation towards a sustainable society, as a response to a number of persistent problems confronting contemporary modern

societies’ (Grin et al., [2010](#)). In short, this lens posits that the environmental problems we face (such as climate change, biodiversity loss and resource depletion) constitute grand challenges that will not be solved by incremental improvements. It involves a fundamental rethinking and radical shifts to how socio-technical systems are configured and function, basically how our societies function. The key insights of a sustainability transition lens are the involvement of multiple dimensions (e.g., technology, culture, markets, infrastructure and policy) and multiple actors (across the public sector, the corporate sector and civil society) coming together in co-evolutionary and uncertain long-term processes of stability and change aiming at sustainability (Köhler et al., [2019](#)). As sustainability transitions are deeply rooted in culture, in [Table 7.1](#) we provide examples of how different cultural perspectives of justice can be linked to sustainability transitions (Köhler et al., [2019](#)).

Table 7.1 Culture and sustainability transformations

Concept	Definition	Application to transitions
Ubuntu	Emphasises the act of building community, friendship and oneness with the larger humanity	Neighbourhoods' efforts to promote energy efficiency, decisions about food resources within a community
Taoism and Confucianism	Emphasises virtue and suggests that the means to an end is more important than the end in itself	Respecting due process in transition decisions, adhering to human rights protections when implementing infrastructural projects
Hinduism and Dharma	Carries the notion of righteousness and moral duty and is always intended to achieve order, longevity and collective well-being	Seeking to minimise the extent and distribution of externalities, offering affordable access to technology to help address poverty
Buddhism	Expounds the notion of selflessness and the pursuit of individual salvation and nirvana	Respecting future generations, minimising harm to the environment and society
Indigenous Perspectives of the Americas	Recognises interdependence of all life and enables good living through responsibility and respect for oneself and the natural world, including other people	Technologies developed cautiously through long-term experience and sovereign cultural protocols, avoiding dramatic transformation of ecosystems, requiring restoration
Animal-centrism	Values and recognises rights of all sentient life	Promoting transition processes or practices such as veganism, vegetarianism or waste reduction that avoid harm and provide benefits to all sentient animals
Biocentrism	Values and respects the will to live and the basic interest to survive and flourish	Promoting transitions that adhere to a fair share of environmental resources among all living beings
Ecocentrism	Gives moral consideration for human and non-human communities and the basic functioning and interdependence of the ecological community as a whole	Advocating technologies or transitions that preserve the integrity, diversity, resilience and flourishing of the whole ecological community

New regulation and legislation also play a key role in (environmental) sustainability transitions. We should note that sustainability transitions realistically involve winners and losers: as the landscape changes, we can see stranded assets (suffering from unanticipated devaluation) and stranded business models. Firms with advanced environmental capabilities are likely to be the winners. At the individual level, these broader transitions are likely to face a major barrier in psychological resistance.

7.4.5 Approaches for Sustainable Organising

In going through the above perspectives, you may have noticed that the corporation is mostly absent. Sustainability innovation concepts come closer to the business firm, although typically still systemic in nature. While business schools and the field of management put the company front and centre, ecological lenses rarely operate within (corporate) organisational boundaries or focus on commercial products. Let's turn to more corporate- and product-oriented lenses by examining how organisational level approaches to environmental sustainability developed over the past decades.

As environmental problems of corporate activity began to surface in the 1960s (see, e.g., Rachel Carson's book *Silent Spring* in [1962](#)), they were first tackled through regulation and legislation by national governments until the 1980s. Since then, the economic philosophy of neoliberalism combined with deregulation and globalization gained more ground. This involved the idea that business enterprises' voluntary environmental action would be more effective than command-and-control legislation. The first incarnation of this thinking was the environmental management systems (EMS) approach which began to emerge in the late 1980s, taking after the quality management movement. The aim of the EMS approach was to control risk and reduce the harm caused by existing business (Welford, [1999](#)).

EMS were not perceived to be entirely satisfactory by business, regulators or the environmental movement. They were seen as incremental and not sufficiently

tackling the environmental problems at hand. What followed was eco-efficiency thinking, introduced to business management by Schmidheiny in the 1990s (Fritsch et al., [1994](#)). The idea was to develop new products, services and eventually business models that 'do more with less'. In other words, eco-efficient solutions would provide the same customer and user needs fulfilment (often called the service unit) with less materials, energy and water, and at the same time, be as or more profitable for the firm providing them. Eco-efficiency thinking kick-started the broader 'win-

win' paradigm of corporate sustainability, moving beyond the environmental sphere. Perhaps the most well-known incarnation of this view is Porter and Kramer's ([2011](#)) creation of shared value, which posits that companies should strive to identify and exploit situations where both the company and society can benefit. This has been dubbed the 'win-win paradigm' of corporate sustainability. While intuitively appealing, it is good to approach a world of win-win opportunities with a healthy dose of scepticism (see King and Pucker, [2021](#)).

Eco-efficient products, services and business models abounded, delivering relative reduction of ecological footprint per service unit. But they did not lead to absolute reduction of negative environmental impacts, but instead to rebound effects where increasing production and consumption overtook the environmental savings gained through efficiency measures. As a result, absolute consumption and absolute use of material kept growing so that material extraction tripled from 1970 to 2015, considerably so during the years when the eco-efficiency ideas were already known (International Resource Panel, [2019](#)). Paradoxically, at a global scale, material productivity, a rough equivalent to absolute material efficiency, dropped (see [Figure 7.4](#)), apparently due to large-scale outsourcing of production to countries with lax environmental regulation and minimal incentives for best available technologies and efficiency. Unfortunately, ultimately, the environment cares only about absolute reduction of environmental impacts and not relative decoupling or reduction.

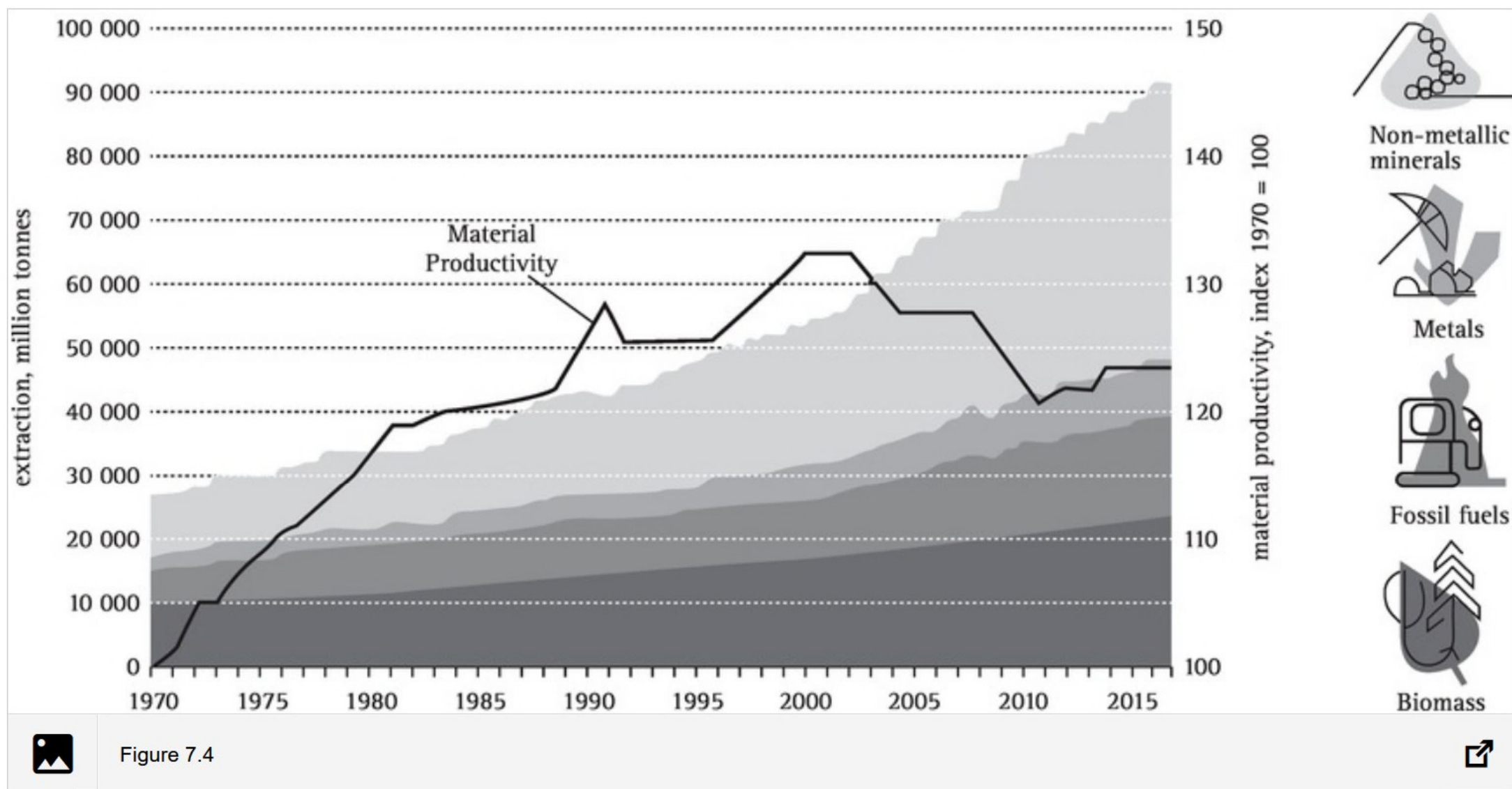


Figure 7.4 Global resource extraction and material productivity 1970–2015.

Source: International Resource Panel (2019: 18).

dominant way for companies to report on sustainability (see [Chapters 1](#) and [17](#) of this book) and it has been translated to Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) within the investor community (see [Chapter 11](#)). In this sense, the ecological aspects of corporate sustainability are categorised as one bucket, typically examined only insofar as they translate to economic risk.

7.4.6 Categorisation of Ecological Lenses

Now that we have reviewed a selected sample of influential lenses to understand corporate sustainability, we can bring them together into one framework depicted in [Figure 7.5](#). We categorise the lenses on two axes: first, whether they prioritise an eco-social or economic perspective; and, second, whether the related discourses focus on environmental opportunities or more critical perspectives related to environmental limits. Each of the twelve lenses discussed above are depicted in this framework. As a caveat, we should note that many of these lenses, such as degrowth and indigenous knowledge, are not easily categorisable as they represent broad perspectives which do not neatly fit into boxes.

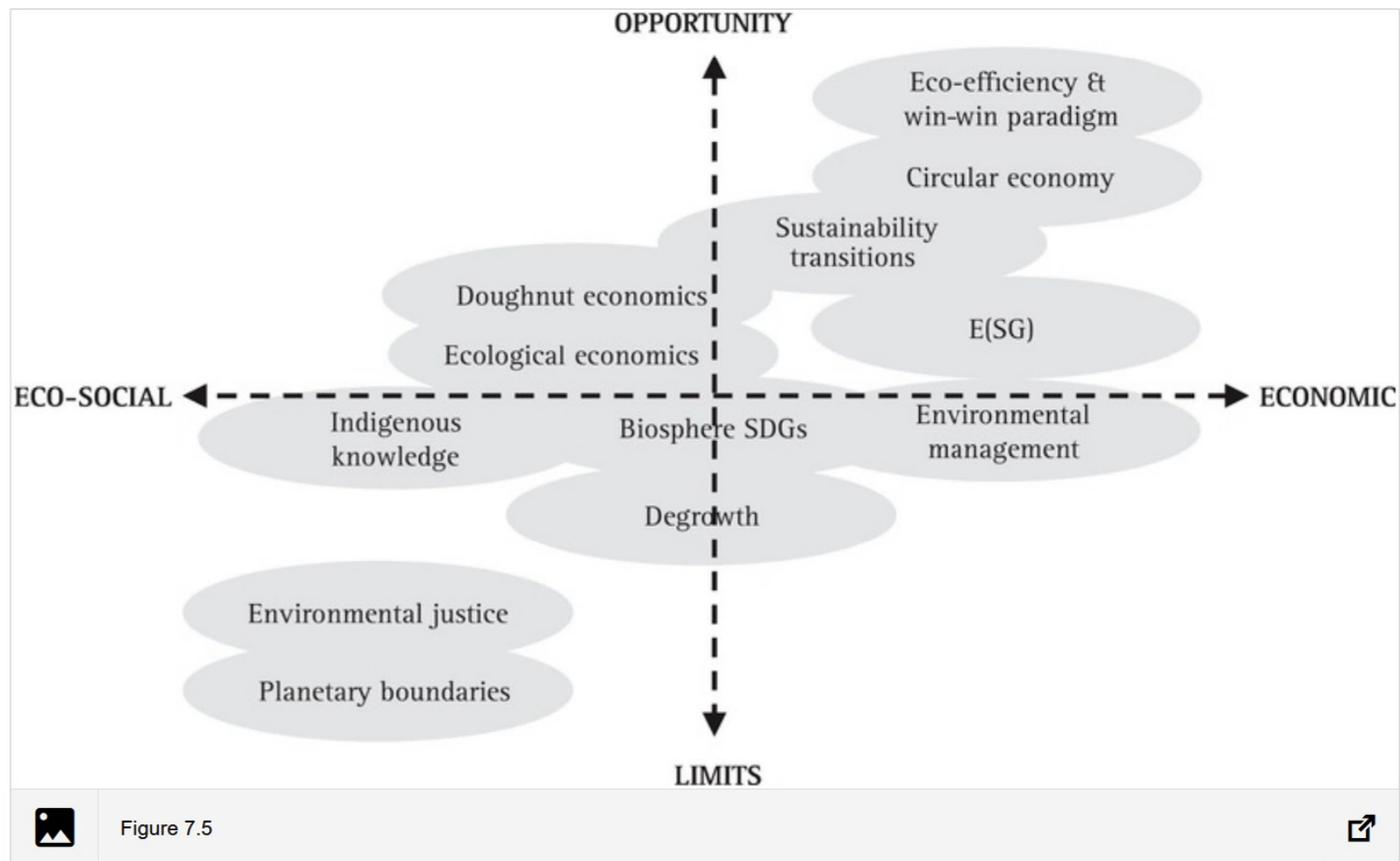


Figure 7.5

When we look at all these lenses, one thing becomes clear. We need to see the so-called triple bottom line of companies – the economic, social and environmental responsibilities and impacts of firms – not as separate spheres, but as deeply interconnected. We need to see the economy, society and environment in a concentric way. This means that we need to have an economy which is for the benefit of

society and an economy and society which operate within planetary boundaries. Ecological sustainability is the fundament upon which sustainable societies and economies can thrive. If ecological sustainability collapses, human life on Earth becomes endangered. Ultimately, the ecological perspective to corporate sustainability calls for this form of balance.

7.5 Chapter Summary

Given all of the largely negative and worrying environmental trends that we have covered, is there any room to be optimistic? Granted, a fair deal of realism is in order and the task(s) ahead can seem daunting. Nonetheless, we should also celebrate prior successes, understand different lenses as ways of seeing the problems, systematically analyse our actions, acknowledge opportunities and (at least we choose to) remain cautiously optimistic. Three things should be kept in mind. First, while (slightly) changing consumption habits will not save the world, small actions do add up. Two popular proverbs come to mind: ‘every journey begins by a single step’ (a version of a Chinese proverb by Lao Tzu); and ‘there is no path, the path is made by walking’ (a Spanish poem by Antonio Machado). At the same time, these small actions need to be coupled with bigger transitions, such as a transition in energy sources. Relatedly, we actually do have the technologies with which to implement major sustainability transitions and these transitions will influence how we lead our daily lives. Second, change is constant. While many changes have involved the deterioration of our natural environment, there are countless positive trends related to, for instance, developments in literacy, health, average life expectancy, scientific discoveries, technological development and increasing wealth. Furthermore, while changing some things around us may seem impossible, it is surprising how fast what has been considered impossible, becomes inevitable. Third, and relatedly, some transitions can happen (surprisingly) fast. In fact, the time after the mid twentieth century up until today has been dubbed ‘the Great Acceleration’. We tend to overestimate change in the short term, but underestimate it in the longer term. When we take a slightly longer time perspective, the pace of change is often overwhelming.

So what can each of us do? We can put into practice the principles listed in this chapter. We can evaluate alternative lenses and actions and their outcomes in an evidence-based manner. We can listen to and try to understand the local context. Without including the people affected by a particular environment problem, an ‘external’ solution is unlikely to work. We can think in the systems in the sense of appreciating the interconnectedness of the different elements of the system. Ultimately, systems thinking is not sufficient, but we need what we call ‘systems action’ leading to positive change. The following sections and chapters of this book

on actors, processes and issues will hopefully provide you with both food for thought and ideas for systems action.